



**NEWS | BAY AREA & STATE**

# ACLU sues Immigration and Customs Enforcement for license plate reader records

By **Sophie Haigney**, *Reporter*

Updated May 28, 2018 3:11 p.m.



mounted on posts at all entry points into the island city.

Paul Chinn / The Chronicle

The American Civil Liberties Union has sued the U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement for records about the agency's use of license-plate reader technology, after ICE apparently failed to turn over records after multiple requests.

---

**ADVERTISEMENT**  
Article continues below this ad

---

“We believe the other is managed by Thomson Reuters,” said Vasudha Talla, an ACLU attorney.

The ACLU and other privacy advocates have expressed concern about how the data will be stored and used for civil immigration enforcement.

In March, the ACLU filed two requests under the Freedom of Information Act seeking records from ICE, including contracts, memos, associated communications, training materials and audit logs. But ICE has not provided any records, the ACLU said in the complaint, which was filed last Tuesday in the District Court for the Northern District of California.

“The excessive collection and storing of this data in databases — which is then pooled and shared nationally — results in a systemic monitoring that chills the

“We have essentially two concerns: one that is general to ALPR databases and one that’s specific to this situation with ICE,” Talla said. “The ACLU has done a lot of work around surveillance technology and ALPR, and we’re generally concerned about the aggregation of all this data about license plates paired with a time and location, stretching back for so many months and years.”

The contract with ICE has heightened concerns about how the data might be used for immigration enforcement, perhaps with data collected by unknowing departments.

“There may be departments who didn’t realize at the time that this might be shared for civil immigration enforcement, who may have never intended to get in bed with ICE and now may have found themselves unknowingly in this situation,” Talla said.

In getting the contracts and other documents, she added, the ACLU seeks clarity on how the data are used, stored and shared.

---

**ADVERTISEMENT**

Article continues below this ad

Danielle Bennett, a spokeswoman for ICE, said the agency could not comment directly on pending litigation with the ACLU.

“However, lack of comment should not be construed as agreement with or stipulation to any of the allegations,” she said in a statement.

Bennett noted that ICE does use license-plate data to aid its investigations.

---

**ADVERTISEMENT**

Article continues below this ad



**BECOME A FRIEND. GET OUR AD-FREE APP.**

Access our new app with ad-free reading, curated maps and more.

We use technologies that provide information about your interactions with this site to others for functionality, analytics, targeted advertising, and other purposes. [Learn more in our Privacy Notice](#). You agree that your use of this website and the Hearst Services is governed by the [Terms of Use](#) (including the [dispute resolution procedures](#)).

database and will not collect nor contribute any data to a national public or private database.”

ICE updated its [privacy impact assessment](#) in 2015 for surveillance tools, and Bennett called the policies “the most stringent requirements known to have been applied for the use of this technology.”

*Sophie Haigney is a San Francisco Chronicle staff writer. Email: [sophie.haigney@sfchronicle.com](mailto:sophie.haigney@sfchronicle.com) Twitter: [@SophieHaigney](https://twitter.com/SophieHaigney)*

May 23, 2018 | Updated May 28, 2018 3:11 p.m.

## **Sophie Haigney**



### **REPORTER**

Sophie Haigney covers breaking news for the San Francisco Chronicle.

She graduated from Yale in 2017 with a degree in English. Before joining The Chronicle, Haigney had internships at The New York Times and The Boston Globe, where she covered arts and culture. She was also an editor of and occasional contributor to the travel magazine Off Assignment.

## **Around The Web**

Powered by **REVCONTENT**

By **SilverPenny**

By **SilverPenny**

## **Forget Collagen, Use This Household Item Instead**

By **Hartford Review Journal**

## **7 Things Changing for Seniors On Social Security In 2027**

By **HealthyWallet**

## **Don't Borrow from the Bank If You Own a Home, Borrow from Yourself Instead (I...**

By **Comparisons.org**

## **The Supportive Bra Women Over 50 Are Loving**

By **imgainting**

## **Cardiologist Warns Americans: "Pour Out the Bottled Water"**

By **Gundry MD**

## **Worst Car Insurance Companies for Overcharging (Is Yours On the List?)**

By **Auto Insurance**

By **Wellness Guide**

## Dark Spot and Wait 3 Minutes

By **ApexLabs**

By **Gundry MD**

### Let's Play



Cross|word



Pile-Up Poker



Typeshift



Really B.

# SFGATE

Top ^



About



Contact



Services



Quick Links



**HEARST** *newspapers* © 2026 Hearst Communications, Inc. [Terms of Use](#) | [Privacy Notice](#) | [CA Notice at Collection](#) |

[Your CA Privacy Rights \(Shine the Light\)](#) | [DAA Industry Opt Out](#) |



Your Privacy Choices (Opt Out of Sale/Targeted Ads)

We use technologies that provide information about your interactions with this site to others for functionality, analytics, targeted advertising, and other purposes. [Learn more in our Privacy Notice](#). You agree that your use of this website and the Hearst Services is governed by the [Terms of Use](#) (including the [dispute resolution procedures](#)).